My Monday Morning: Lee Pace

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AI Executive Summary

1. Core Thesis: Actor and villain Lee Pace explores how specific, non-negotiable rituals structure his creative process and daily life, asserting that consistency in routine provides stability amidst chaotic projects like playing a witch or complex clones for *Foundation*. He argues that acting involves both rigid preparation (training/fitness) and fluid adaptation, while personal calm is derived from physical exhaustion rather than digital stimulation.

2. Key Arguments & Data:

3. **Acting First Credit:** Lee Pace recalls his first IMDB credit as a bad guy in *Law & Order SVU*, noting he knew nothing of acting beforehand and required a 30-minute warmup period with Mariska Hargitay crouching to adjust eye line for camera focus.
4. **Villain Archetype:** Playing antagonists or "heels" is described as perverted fun; the audience's enjoyment is central to the actor's creative satisfaction.
5. **Film Production (Practical Magic 2):** The first shot involves an unconscious character spell-cast by Sandra Bullock and Nicole Kidman; Pace describes their voices as hypnotic and found them difficult to predict in comedy timing despite being skilled at the craft.
6. **Superstition & Protection:** Pace identifies "witches" in real life, distinguishing between those who manipulate choices (evil) and those who open experiences (magical). He acknowledges a fear of getting the "evil eye" regarding bad witches and protects himself against them.
7. **Theater vs. Film Rituals:** Unlike film, theater involves a more rigid warmup ritual ("stretch," "voice together") because there is no editing; George C. Wolfe's philosophy that "theater is the actor's revenge" is cited as a goal to make the audience feel like church rather than just seeing a performance.
8. **Dream Role:** Pace has not played an animal (specifically in a dog scene from school), viewing playing non-human roles as his ultimate aspiration after playing elves and warlords.

9. **Morning Routine:** Wakes at 6:37 AM with 30 minutes of worry; makes a strong stovetop violetti moacha for six cups; does not rely on caffeine but prioritizes the ritual over sleep quality or productivity.
10. **Fitness Strategy (Foundation):** Starts Monday with chest day (bench press) to build pump; works with trainer Ian Benson since the beginning of the show; lifts heavy weight without anger/rage, viewing gossip and relaxation during workouts as preferable alternatives.
11. **Farm & Garden:** Maintains paths on a 10-acre meadow using a brush hog in late August/September for golden rod bloom; prunes trees in winter; planted 20 maple trees which have tripled in size over the years.
12. **Mental Health Advice:** Avoids "doomscrolling" (AI videos, etc.) as it agitates and takes focus out of control; recommends swimming for an hour to induce exhaustion and quietness as a method of relaxation.

13. **Philosophical Guideline:** Cites advice from "Not my pig not my farm," summarized as "That's not my business," implying acceptance of things outside one's control.

14. Actionable Takeaways:

15. **Prioritize Ritual Over Efficiency:** Create morning routines based on the act itself (e.g., coffee preparation) rather than caffeine utility to build a psychological anchor.
16. **Implement Physical Decompression:** Use strenuous exercise (e.g., swimming for an hour) to achieve exhaustion and mental quietness before facing digital content or work tasks.
17. **Curate Digital Intake:** Avoid platforms that deliver algorithmic noise, such as AI-generated videos or absurd content, which serve as sources of agitation rather than calm.
18. **Adopt Control Acceptance:** Apply the "not my business" philosophy to reduce mental load by deciding when things are too big for your control and moving on.
19. **Structure Creative Process:** Use specific warmup rituals (like stretching and voice preparation) to manage performance pressure, especially when no editing is involved in the delivery process.

Full Transcript

I'm Lee Pace, and this is my Monday morning. Hey, I'm Lane Fleursheim, and this is a show where I talk to people who are great at what they do about the routines and rituals that keep them going. Today, I'm talking with actor Lee Pace. You might know him from cult favorites like The Fall, or as a villain in the Marvel Universe, or even as an elven king in The Hobbit.

This fall, he's starring alongside two beloved witches, Sandra Bullock and Nicole Kidman in Practical Magic 2. For his Monday morning, Lee told me about spotting witches in real life, tending to his garden, and of course, how he starts his week. We'll get into it right after the break. Your first credit, at least on IMDB, is Law and Order SVU. And you play a bad guy behind bars. We call it the New York City Yearbook because all the actors in New York do Law and Order SVU at some point. No, it's like the quintessential first credit, right? Yeah, perfect. But I was wondering, like, do you remember when you got that call that you got the part, what it was like being on that set and being grilled by Benson and Stabler?

I knew nothing. I mean, I actually knew nothing. I remember Mariska Hargitay who was so sweet. I worked for half a day, you know. It was the first time I was really in front of a camera. I was so new to it. And she, you know, kind of crouched so that her eye line was close to the lens. And I was like, why is she standing like that? Why is she doing that crazy thing? I realized now that it was just to kind of keep my eyes closer to the lens so I could, so that you could see, you know, when I was doing better. Yeah, it was overwhelming. And yeah, I remember it. There's so many days on set that I don't remember, but I remember that one. Yeah. In general, what's the best part of playing a bad guy or a villain? I mean, it's fun. Yeah. It's just, there's a kind of creative fun to it. And I think the audience has a good time with the heel, right? Yeah, definitely. And the worst that I am, the more fun, I think. So it's perverse, but I'm into it. And you're about to star in Practical Magic 2, and the first time that the audience sees your character Ian Wright, he's unconscious and unclothed under a spell. What else can you share about him? I mean, the day I shot that, that was also the first thing that I

shot on the movie. And it began with kind of laying there with my eyes closed.

And I hear Sandra Bullock and the Kidman's, Nicole Kidman's voice kind of entering the room talking and they both have such, I mean, memorable voices, but beautiful. Like the sound of their voices are so, you know, hypnotic. So I was laying there just thinking, I cannot believe I'm about to have this experience. Sandra Bullock and Nicole Kidman, like, doing a spell on me. Yeah. That is wild. Yeah. They're, they're so good at what they do. And so, I mean, to watch Sandra Bullock put together these, the comedy of what a character is going to do is not something I understand really how to kind of construct, you know, the timing of a bit like that. So it was fun to watch her work, but I learned a lot watching her, you know, Be creative in this way and skilled being in a movie about witches. Do you have any superstitions? I don't really have superstitions, but I but I suppose I'm I guess aware of I mean I can spot a witch Oh, yeah? Yeah, definitely. Because when you just encounter someone who has a magic about them, and there's lots of different kinds of witches, obviously, there's a witch that can put a spell on you and you find yourself doing things that they want you to do without making that choice for yourself. And then there are witches that I've known that just open up experiences for you that you would, that are magical. You know, the timing of them works out in a way of like, like, how did this happen? You know, how did this, I mean, both Sandra and Nicole both have very, like, good witch elements about them. So I suppose that that is, I guess, a magic that I'm, I feel lucky that I've encountered, but there are bad witches too.

Tell me about some of those encounters. I mean, you don't want to talk about them because you don't want to get the evil eye on you. Right. You know, that's a real thing. True. So, even with the bad ones, they're definitely like, okay, I'm gonna protect myself. Right. Well, I was also going to ask, like, do you have any rituals in your own life, like either around acting or other elements of your life? I mean, as far as acting goes, every... every movie is different, every director is different, every character is different. So I don't have a very rigid way of approaching it. I went to a drama school that kind of teaches you a lot of tools that it's like sometimes, okay, well, that's a way to think about this and figure out a way into the character. And

when I've done a play, the warmup is a ritual. You know, it's nice to go out on the stage and, you know, stretch.

get your voice together, think about like what the hell is gonna happen tonight. Because when it's just you and the audience, George C. Wolfe, a director I worked with who I learned so much from, he's such a master. He said that theater is the actor's revenge because there's no director editing what you're doing. The timing is yours. And, you know, those great stage actors talk about like casting a spell. They can get all of the people in that house, you know, leaning forward and feeling the same thing at the same time. And that's those moments when you can kind of feel that happening from up on the stage. I mean, it's not to sound too corny, but it's more like church than theater. It really does feel like a magical thing that happens.

So that's obviously the goal and, you know, the warm-up. I think helps you think, okay, this is what is about to happen. I'm going to stand on that stage. I'm going to need to move in a way that they see my whole body. And I want my voice to be prepared to communicate what I needed to communicate. Do you have a dream role you haven't played yet? A dream role. You know, when I was in school, I did a scene where I played a dog. I think about that from time to time and I think it would be because I've played elves and vampires and alien warlords. I do a lot of that kind of thing. So one thing I have not done is an animal. So I don't know if there's, you know, a role out there for me where I can play like really not a human. After the break, Lee gets into his Monday morning routine.

So what time do you usually get up on a Monday and what's the first thing you do after getting up? Well, I guess I wake up at about 6 37 and lay there for about 30 minutes and worry about things And then I get up and start the day make the coffee Well, that was my next question. What do you do for coffee and breakfast? I make a mocha So one of those stovetop violetti things and I make kind of a big one I get

about, it says for like six people, six cups. So it's a pretty strong coffee. And I don't really do it for the caffeine, because I don't notice the caffeine in coffee. It's just the ritual of it. It's like, I mean, I can't imagine starting my day without this big, strong coffee. Yeah. Are you drinking all six cups? Yeah. Nice. And we always ask about workout routine in this column and

I'm particularly excited to talk to you about this because I know that you just wrapped shooting the fourth season of Foundation and in it you play a different clone of the same Emperor character and not only that but you give the character a different body each season working with your trainer. So I wanted to ask about that process and just you know what did that look like this time and how does that compare to your normal workout routine?

Well, Monday is chest day. So, you kind of start the week with, you know, the bench press, all the chest exercises so you can get the pump. So, I always look forward to chest day because it takes Sundays off. And, well, Saturdays too, mostly. So, it's a fun way to start the workouts for the week. And Dury Foundation, yeah, working on as a big part of preparing the character. I love Ian Benson, who's the trainer that I work with on this show. We've been working together on Foundation since day one. And not only is he just like a really good person, smart and knowledgeable about what we're trying to achieve and in it for the long haul, which, you know, it takes a lot of discipline and effort to to change your body. But we just laugh a lot and we can spend an hour and a half gossiping. Best kind of workout. And I like a relaxing workout. I want to lift a lot of weight, but I also don't want to get angry. I see guys in the gym just get so mad. Thanks.

And I have to ask, what's the hair care routine? What's the secret? I don't really give a lot of thought to that. I only kind of cut my hair if I'm working, but I'm, you know, I've usually got a pretty messy head of hair. So that requires no maintenance. Easiest routine. I believe you live upstate on a farm part of the time. Do you have routines around that? Like, are you feeding animals or spending a lot of time outside? Well, I mean, the only animals I keep are chickens, because I don't have good fences. And they would get out. So, and a dog. But what about my routines? It's more like yearly routines, because you do different things with the garden at different times in here. I have these paths that I maintain all through the farm.

you know, you have to mow them. I've got to, you know, tractor with the brush hog and because I don't mow it with like a finished mower. I just mow it so we can run around and get access to the property because I like the way the meadows look when they're wild, especially this time of year because, you know, late August into September, the golden rod kicks off

and it's like, I've got, you know, a big wild meadow. You know, it's probably about 10 acres this particular meadow. And when I have nice paths mowed through it, I mean, it's like one of the coolest things that the farm does throughout the year. It sounds magical. Yeah, it's so nice. And then, you know, there's different chores during the winter, obviously. You can prune the trees and stuff. So it's more, I guess, the routines are that way. I like to plant trees. So I have a lot of trees.

on the property and as the years have gone by it's been incredibly rewarding watching them grow. I planted this big circle of maple trees and it's about 20 trees. So it's really big and they've almost tripled in size. So now the center of it is, you know, this great shady spot. It's one of my favorite places on the farm. Do you read there or anything? We just kind of walked through it. Just kind of walked through nice. How do you think about balancing work and life? Like what do you do to relax or find calm? I find a lot of calm swimming because it's really, I mean if you swim for an hour you're exhausted, which is a nice feeling. And it's quiet. So finding quiet I think is a calming thing. Do you doom scroll?

Yeah, I have my moment. It's the worst, isn't it? Yeah, it's just the opposite of swimming for an hour. No, it's like getting yourself wound up about nothing, actually. It's like nothing that you have any control over. You're being bombarded with things that are gonna agitate you. Like, and you can't stop. Why do we do it? It's the worst. Like, that's one thing that happens on set that I really It's like I stopped bringing my phone to set because you end up having some downtime and you want to kind of knock, you know, knock your brain away from and you get there and it's just a bunch of crap. Right. It probably really takes you out of the focus of it all. Yeah. But you know, I guess my algorithm just gives me absurd things. Like lately I get a lot of these AI Very dramatic AI cat videos or absolutely like they're so dumb Actually so funny. Yeah, and what's a piece of advice you've gotten that's guided you or been important to you in life? I forget who gave it to me but Not my pig not my farm which is basically to say that's not my business. Yeah That's not my business. Good advice. Well, thank you so much for joining us for My Monday Morning. This was really fun having you. Thank you so much. I enjoyed talking to you. Thank you. Thank you for having me. My Monday Morning is part of The Journal, which is a co-production

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and follow me on Instagram, atlanfloresheim for more behind-the-scenes stuff from my Monday morning and to let me know what you think of the show. This episode was produced by Jeevika Verma and edited by Catherine Brewer and Sarah Platt. Video production by Nathan Singapok. Original music by Nathan Singapok. Thanks so much for joining us.